

v5 corrections per user directive: 1. No mythology around Silence. The katana is a katana. No corundum strop, no piezoelectric draw, no charge, no "literature on Silence," no boss who paid to train against an exotic countermeasure. The boss is a swordsman who lost to a better one. 2. No parenthetical narrator asides. All humor woven into the actual sentences. Worldbuilding info comes through the action, not in (...) blocks.

Bearing Teeth

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I — Teeth

The freight elevator was the only thing in the building that worked.

The resident elevator had been there once. There was a shaft, and there were doors on every floor, and a piece of paper taped to one of them said OUT OF SERVICE in three languages, none of them recent. The corporation that had built it had filed bankruptcy in 2207, gotten bought, gotten bought again, and ended up in the portfolio of Carrion Logistics LLC, the body-pickup federation, which did not maintain the resident elevator and also did not maintain the bodies. In the Gray Zone this counted as integrated service.

Kyle rode the freight up. The cage was steel grating with a fine carpet of pulverized concrete on the floor — somebody had moved a refrigerator earlier, or somebody had moved a man, or somebody had moved both and the man had complained less. The ceiling LED had been the wrong color since 2218 and bathed everything in the institutional green of a hospital cafeteria at three in the morning. The cage went up at the speed the cage had decided on without consulting anybody.

The airshaft brought the building's news up the side of the cage like a wet radio. Camphor from the second floor — somebody's grandmother, joints, a salve that had been working for years on a pain that had outworked it. Burnt rice from the fifth — Mr. Yu, eighty-three, refused to use a timer because his mother had not, and his rice had been burnt every Thursday since 2189, a tradition to him and an indictment to his neighbors. And tonight, from somewhere between four and seven, the smell of Chen Wei-Lin's deep fryer: pork bone, scallion, oil that had not been changed since the lunar new year because the oil was the seasoning.

It struck Kyle, somewhere around the sixth floor, as a clean little parable. The work was always already there before you got to it. The smell was the contract.

He stepped off on the eighth floor and the building knew his answer before he did.

Unit 802 was at the end of the hall behind a door that had been painted four different times at four different attempts at the color white. Mrs. Chen answered before the second knock.

"Come in, Mr. Corbin."

She had been working on his name through the duration of the phone call and had landed on *Mr. Corbin*, which was correct in the way calling a man by his middle name with *Mr.* in front was correct. He let it go. The array catalogued her face whether he wanted it to or not — 83% Cantonese, 11% Hakka, scar on the left thumb-base from a slip with a cleaver at nine or ten in a kitchen with poor task lighting — and he set the read aside the way he had been setting it aside since nineteen, when a Vietnamese-Senegalese stevedore in a bar had explained at some length the social cost of saying that kind of count out loud, an explanation that had taken Kyle's right eyebrow some time to recover from.

The apartment was three rooms and a curtain. A folding chair, a low table, a television last turned on the year before last and now serving as the surface where the family kept clementines, envelopes, and a small carved wooden frog with a chip out of its left back leg. He suspected the daughter.

The husband was in the corner. A wicker chair, two breaks in the cane, both wrapped in electrical tape. He sat with his weight off the broken places like a man who had been sitting like that for twenty-nine days and had stopped expecting the rest of the chair back. His jaw was wired with the four-point titanium a Gray Zone field clinic put in when there was no budget for plates and was not going to be. The wire had been pulled tight before the swelling went down, which the patient had discovered on day three when the swelling went down and the wire stayed tight. He breathed through his nose, slow and even, the way a man breathed who had been breathing through his nose since March.

"My husband's name is Liu," Mrs. Chen said. She offered the introduction as if it might matter. It did. "He was a cook. He was a very good cook."

Liu blinked once at Kyle. The blink was the bow. Kyle returned it, smaller, in the way men returned bows in rooms where speech was not an even option for everybody present.

The light in the room was the color of weak tea. The fixture had been wired into the airshaft duct fifteen years ago by a tenant who had not been an electrician but had been confident, and the bulb the tenant had installed was a 2210 closeout from a Wicker hardware store that no longer existed. There were forty-six of those bulbs left in the world. Chen Wei-Lin had bought twelve in 2218 and was on her seventh. The window across the room looked at the tower opposite, close enough to read the laundry on its eighth-floor balcony — a family of three or four, an aspirational interest in linen — and behind the laundry the canyon was full of rain. Warm rain at this tier; the upper-tier rain came from cloud and was cold, the lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of HVAC and was warm by the time it got down here, which the people on the eighth floor had been hearing on their metal awning four floors below for thirty-seven years and had stopped registering as a sound. In another window two buildings over a man was arguing with a ride-share AI about a routing question. Kyle could not hear him. The argument was visible in the shoulders, which were doing the thing shoulders did when they had been losing a conversation for four to six minutes. He wished the man well.

"The men who came," Mrs. Chen said.

"Yes."

"There were six. The one I want is named Tien." She gestured with one hand at her husband, small and economical, the gesture of a woman who did not want to enlarge the wound by pointing at it. "He hit my husband three times with the back of a wrench. The first on the side of the head. The second on the jaw. The third on the jaw also. After the third he was satisfied."

"Why."

"The license."

She said it as if she had been certain he would understand the word in the specific sense it was used in this building on this floor. He did. The stall license was three thousand Φ a year, issued through Carrion Logistics LLC and payable in twelve installments unless you missed one, in which case payable in one installment plus interest plus a visit from a man named Tien. The invoice itemized the visit as *Compliance Verification*. The honesty of Carrion Logistics LLC's billing department was a matter on which Kyle had opinions and tonight had no time for.

"You were short this month."

"Eight hundred."

"Why."

"The cold snap. We ran the fryer harder. The gas bill cleared on the third. The eight hundred would have been in the box on the third. Tien came on the second."

"On purpose."

"On purpose."

A figure moved behind the curtain into the second room. The breathing pattern had been there since the hallway: child, female, twelve to fourteen, has been doing this for some time. The curtain shifted now and a face appeared at it. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was not one a child should be having to wear.

She did not come in. She did not retreat. She watched.

Kyle did not look at her directly. Looking at her would put her in the conversation, and the conversation was not for her. Mrs. Chen had not turned. Mrs. Chen knew her daughter was there. Mrs. Chen had decided, possibly tonight, possibly six years ago, that *daughter sees what daughter*

sees was a discipline of a kind she could not protect against and would not try to.

The damp credits came out of Mrs. Chen's apron in a thin stack banded with a pink hair-elastic. She pressed them into his palm with both hands. He felt the weight and ran the count: six hundred and forty Φ . Half the standing rate.

"I do not have all of it, Mr. Corbin."

"It is enough."

"I do not have all of it because—"

"Mrs. Chen. It is enough."

She had the specific exhaustion of a woman who had practiced the sentence seven times and had now been told the sentence was not required. The relief did not arrive in her face. It arrived in her hands; they stopped trembling at the second knuckle of the index first, the thumbs after, the rest on a half-second delay, the way circulation came back to a limb that had been folded under itself in sleep.

Two stories up, someone began playing a Cantonese pop song from 2218 that had been a hit then and was not now but had been the song the building played at funerals for the four years it had been a hit. Whether Unit 1004 had chosen it on purpose or the algorithm had served it on some confluence of recent searches the algorithm did not have permission to disclose, the effect was the same. The song was not, on this occasion, for Liu Chen. Liu Chen was still alive. The song was, in a manner of speaking, on retainer.

"You will be careful, Mr. Corbin."

"I will be efficient."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

She bowed. He bowed. The bows were the contract. She told him the rest of what he had come to know — the address at the bottom of the eastern strut, the side door that nobody locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the side door, the front door that nobody locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the front, the schedule of when Tien drank and slept and did the thing he did instead of work. Sable had already given Kyle the same information through the cracked terminal the previous Tuesday. He had known where Tien would be before he had climbed the stairs. He had come anyway because Mrs. Chen needed to give him the address. The address was the gift she had to deliver in order to be the person who delivered it.

He left through the door he had come in. On the ride down a phrase arrived in his head — *the bill is the bill, the boy is the bill* — in a diction that was not his and a register a dead test subject from the Atlas program had used as their own, and Kyle said *no* aloud to the empty cage and the channel went quiet. The boy from the Grind held. He always did. Eventually.

The bike was where he had left it, two blocks east under a tier-six awning that did most of the work of keeping it dry. Matte black, unbranded, three plates magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. He swapped to the one issued to a Carrion Logistics LLC subcontractor in 2206 that had never been cancelled — the Gray Zone surveillance grid was a forty-year-old corporation cast-off that let a Carrion plate go anywhere a Carrion plate had ever been, and Carrion plates had been most places. The bike rolled clean. He had spent two hours that afternoon repairing a tensioner he could have replaced for forty Φ . Forty Φ was two of Mrs. Chen's bowls. The math came out the way the math came out.

He rode south. Twenty-two minutes of switchbacks down freight ramps the corporations had stopped maintaining around the second tier rezoning, each ramp dropping him about eight stories. By the third ramp the architecture had stopped pretending to be architecture and had become what it actually was, which was welded industrial grief. By the fifth, the rain was warmer. The sky where he could see it was the bruise the GLMZ sky was at this hour — orange under, indigo over, the Pulse-corridor light pollution

running east-west across the middle like a healing scar. A VTOL crossed the gap between two towers a long way overhead, running lights amber, climbing toward the corporation roof-traffic stratum. Some board director was late to dinner. Forty stories below the board director, in a stairwell that smelled like ammonia, a child whose grandmother had died because the building's stair lighting did not work was learning to read the dark. These two facts were the city. Kyle did not file the running lights. He had stopped filing the running lights in his twenties.

A second VTOL crossed the same gap the other way, going the wrong way for an Arcturus board-floor late-shift commute, which suggested either the first VTOL's wife meeting it halfway or the first VTOL's tax attorney, who sometimes was. The bike was running clean. The chain was good.

His left forearm carried no bracer. The katana rode his right shoulder in a matte friction sheath — a hundred and two centimeters of carbon-edged steel forged on a Tuesday in 2199 by a man named Dae-jung Seo in the back room of a repair shop that had been a repair shop because Seo had thought *swordsmith* was too loud a word for what he did. Seo had given Kyle the blade along with the work that came with it on the same Tuesday. The blade had been a sword for eleven years now and was a sword still. Other things were said about it on the street. Kyle had stopped correcting the other things. The people he had corrected had a way of dying mid-correction, and dying mid-correction did not adjust anyone's opinion of the sword. *Silence*, somebody had called it, and the name had stuck because the city named everything it wanted to talk about, including things it had been wrong about, including this one.

Kyle parked the bike a block out and walked.

The loading dock sat at the bottom of the eastern strut where the strut met the tier-zero substrate and the substrate was just concrete without further architectural pretense. Six bays. Two roller doors open. The light inside was the amber sodium of overheads installed before LED was a word, which made everything look like a polaroid in a kitchen drawer.

At the corner of the alley a man with a backpack was trying to sell stolen ramen to a stevedore who did not want stolen ramen. The stevedore had a sandwich in one hand and the conversational stamina of a man on his break, which was to say none. They were still working it out when Kyle walked past. Neither looked up. Neither would, later, remember they had been there. Kyle would, but Kyle remembered everything, which was a feature of the hardware and not of Kyle.

He came in through the front because surprise was free.

Six men. Card game on a crate. They were playing pai gow with hand-marked tiles because somebody had spilled something on the cards a week ago and nobody had replaced them. Tien was winning. Tien was always winning, because Tien beat the others when Tien lost, and the others had figured this out and had agreed, quietly, to let Tien win. None of this was on the dock floor where Kyle could read it; the array offered him the dynamic anyway on inference from posture, betting pattern, and the specific tension in the wrists of the two men Tien had cleaned out last round.

The two chrome-arm men were leaning against a stack of dollies — Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9 series by the wrist articulation pattern, corporate arms in the fifteen-to-eighteen-thousand- Φ bracket, the kind a man wore when he had earned them in service to a corporation he no longer worked for and was not in a hurry to part with. Neither of them had taken Hydraulic Solutions up on the 2222 recall for the elbow-flexor lock at full extension, because the recall required a certified clinic, which required identification, which required Carrion Logistics, which required a conversation about why they needed identification, which they had preferred not to have. The recall was therefore, in a small but specific sense, still alive on both arms.

Of the four seated, one had subdermal thoracic plating visible as faint geometric ridges along the collar — low-end clinic, fast install, no aftercare. One had chrome knuckles and a face the array put at nineteen, augmentation strictly cosmetic and very fresh. One had no visible work, which meant whatever he had was internal, which meant expensive, which meant he had made decisions. The last had a face rebuilt cheap and tight on

the left side, the skin pulled the wrong way over the lower mandible, the parts of his face having run out somewhere along the line. Tien.

The laughter died at the tempo laughter always died when the math changed in a room. It died last in the chrome-knuckle kid, who was nineteen and had not yet learned to read tempo.

The boss set his tiles face down on the crate.

"You lost, friend?"

"Looking for Tien."

The boss looked at Tien. Tien looked at the boss. The boss looked back at Kyle. He had decided to make this take one more sentence than it strictly needed to, which was the decision of a man who had not yet been told the math had finished resolving.

"Tien is occupied."

"He won't be."

The boss did the head-tilt men did when they wanted the room to know something interesting was happening. The chrome-knuckle kid's hand began to move toward his waistband, telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed. The two chrome-arm men shifted their weight a quarter inch each, hydraulic shoulders waking the actuator buses. The subdermal-plated man set his tiles down. Tien sat very still and watched, which was Tien's correct response — Tien had made it to thirty-four in this work by knowing exactly which fights were his and exactly which fights were not.

Kyle's chest warmed. Not the bracer he was not wearing. The array. A coal blown to life behind the sternum, thirty-two thousand electrodes coming up from rest cycle to operating cycle. The room rendered in the second channel — six bodies, six firing solutions, the kid's forearm flexor tightening, the saya inside the boss's coat visible to the array and invisible to anyone who did not know to look for the way the fabric draped. The boss was carrying a

katana inside his coat at a card game on a Tuesday night. That was a choice a man made when a man was expecting somebody.

The boss had been expecting Kyle. Somebody had paid him to be here tonight with a sword, prepared. Somebody had wanted, specifically, to see what a Korean blade did against the man people had been telling stories about for two years. Kyle filed the somebody. He would think about it later.

"Kyle from down the street."

The boss smiled. Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

Crack — crack-crack-crack.

Four shots in three seconds. Buckshot at the chrome-knuckle kid's right knee — the joint separated rather than bent, and he went down sideways with the sound a body made when screaming required more composure than the body had. Slug at the subdermal man's left knee — his fighting philosophy ended at his chest and the kneecap had not been consulted. Slug at the near chrome-arm man's right knee — hydraulics did not load-bear on the leg and the leg had been the leg. Slug at Tien's left knee, because Tien's face was the face Kyle wanted on the floor at an angle that would loosen teeth.

The far chrome-arm man had started his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second, which was the correct response from a fighter with hydraulic reach and a head start on the geometry. Kyle stepped under the arc — the arm passed where his collarbone had been — and brought the katana up. Right hand over the right shoulder. The draw was the draw. The blade cleared the saya in one continuous motion. He put the edge into the shoulder seam where chrome met flesh — three and a half centimeters of unprotected actuator housing exposed at the cooling vent — and the edge passed through the gap the way an edge passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. The arm did not stop. The arm finished its swing into empty air without its owner. The motor bus was severed at the shoulder; the rest of the man did what bodies did when load-bearing chrome stopped sending signals. Then the elbow flexor locked at full extension, because Hydraulic Solutions had told him for four years to

bring it in and he had never gotten around to it, and the dead arm went stiff at his side like a man hailing a cab.

Three seconds. Four shots. One sword cut. Five men down. Four kneecaps still bleeding out their respective contracts with the floor.

Tien made a noise face-down in the drainage channel that was not really a noise.

Kyle turned.

The boss had stood up. He had not drawn during the count. He had stood the way a man stood when he had watched his crew dismantle on schedule and had decided it was now his turn. The hand that went to his hip came back with a katana, the saya having been inside the coat, and the blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo, point neither high nor low, weight settling into a guard that had not been borrowed from any school Kyle could name. The man knew his work.

"Sloppy entrance," the boss said, evenly, like a teacher correcting homework. The Korean was inflected through the English in the careful way of someone who had paid for the English along with the swordwork.

Kyle did not answer. There was nothing the boss had said that Kyle needed to respond to, and the answer the room required was not in language.

They closed.

First exchange. The boss tested the line — a short cut at Kyle's right shoulder, no commitment, the kind of strike a swordsman used to read his opponent's reach. Kyle's blade rose. The steel met edge to flat at a shallow angle and rang a clean sustained note in the concrete. *Tang.* The boss read his information, stepped back, no expression. His weight stayed off the front foot.

Second exchange. Kyle pressed. Two-step advance, cut high right. The boss deflected rather than parried — a clean piece of work, his blade sliding along Kyle's flat to redirect the force past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative.

The boss had paid a lot of money to be conservative against this fight specifically and the conservative answer was, in a normal swordfight, correct. The man had told Kyle something useful in return: he would not take an edge-to-edge meeting if he could avoid it.

Third exchange. The boss committed. Cut high left, fast, clean, no telegraph — a body that had decided to commit and committed. Kyle's parry was a fraction late because the boss had given him nothing to read, and the follow-through grazed his left forearm. Three inches of skin opened — vein not artery, two centimeters lateral of the radial, would impair grip on the shotgun side in approximately ninety seconds. Blood came up immediately. The boss saw it and read it as the answer to the question he had been asking, which was *am I better than the man this is supposed to be*. He had decided he was. He had paid the kind of money you paid to decide that, and the deciding had become part of the asset he had been paid for.

Fourth exchange. The thrust. Straight, committed, full extension, the line clean. Kyle did not meet it at the edge or the flat. He met it at the seppa — the small collar between the tsuba and the blade — and the thrust locked there, blade to blade, no give. Kyle drove forward. He kept the lock. He let his edge ride along the flat of the boss's steel like a skate on ice, the edge tracking from tip toward middle toward tsuba, and where the boss's blade met the boss's hand, the edge met the boss's right wrist.

Bone. Tendon. The radial and ulnar arteries. The median nerve. The carpal architecture that had held a sword for whatever number of years the boss had been training for this duel.

The boss's right hand and the boss's katana fell together to the corrugated steel.

Clang.

The boss looked at his wrist. He looked at his sword on the floor. He looked at Kyle.

"Oh," he said.

The brachial did most of the work. He bled out in nineteen seconds. The array timed it. The array timed everything. Twenty-three seconds for the duel, twenty-six on the dock floor end to end.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes. He had learned to use the window.

He sheathed the blade. A thin line of red near the kissaki; he wiped it against the boss's coat before the steel seated. Chorus went back into the holster. Four chambers spent, one slug still in the cylinder. He registered the count the way other people registered the time.

The boss's face, the array offered him on closing — for the file, because the array did not have a setting for *do not file* — was 71% Korean, 22% Han, 7% noise. Somebody, somewhere, had spent money in Seoul to send a Korean swordsman to Chicago to fight a samurai who lived above a noodle stall. Whoever the somebody was, they had spent the money for the lesson. The lesson was now ambient on the floor of a loading dock in the Gray Zone at 0157 in the morning, and the somebody, wherever they were, was about to learn what the money had bought them. Kyle filed the somebody in the second channel along with the first somebody he had filed at the threshold, and the two somebodies turned out, on inspection, to be the same somebody, which simplified the bookkeeping but not the work.

Tien was crying. Not screaming. Crying. He had figured out by the third kneecap shot that he was not going to die tonight, and the prospect of *not dying tonight* in his current condition was now striking him as worse than the alternative.

Kyle moved through the bodies, methodical. He was looking for the third tooth.

He had two in his left hand already — two loose ones, recovered with a thumb and forefinger from the steel where Tien's face had landed. The third was still seated. He found Tien's mouth and, with the careful neutrality of a man pulling a nail out of a board, gripped the third tooth and turned. It came free with a sound that was not really a sound. Tien sobbed once, briefly, and

stopped, because what he had been sobbing about was no longer at the top of the list.

Kyle stood up with the teeth in his hand.

He had decided what he was going to do with them on the ride down, twenty-two minutes ago, somewhere around the fifth switchback. The thinking had taken about a minute. The remaining twenty-one minutes of the ride had been spent confirming he had not missed an option. He had not missed an option. The option was correct, and it was the kind of correct that an old man named Hammurabi had been writing tablets about three and a half millennia before Kyle had been born, and the boy from the Grind had not been taught Hammurabi at the coronation public-education branch that had closed in 2208, but the math of *what a family was owed* was not the kind of math a teacher had to teach.

Across the dock, behind the ventilation unit on the far wall, the breathing pattern Kyle had tracked since the threshold shifted. Twelve, maybe thirteen. The breathing had been there in Unit 802 too. She had come down. He did not know how she had done it. He did not need to know.

She had come to see.

Kyle walked to the ventilation unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall, blood-misted shape in the dock's bad amber — and waited. The breathing stopped. Then a slow movement. A face came around the corner of the unit. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was a child's expression that had not been issued to a child before tonight.

Kyle crouched. He went down to her eye level the way he went down to a child's eye level whenever the situation gave him room to. Seo had said it once, in the room behind the repair shop, when Kyle was eighteen and a child had walked past the open door: *be at their height when you speak to them*. Kyle did not know whether Seo had originated the line or had quoted it. Seo had quoted a lot of people and had not always cited.

Kyle opened his hand.

The three teeth lay in his palm. Two intact. The third with a hairline fracture from where he had gripped it. The smell of blood was the smell of blood.

The girl looked at his hand. Then at his face. Then back at his hand. She had not yet processed what he was offering her, because what he was offering her did not have a category.

"Present these to your father." His voice was even. He had practiced even for a long time. "I think he will appreciate the gesture."

She looked at the teeth. Then at him. Then at the teeth. Then at him.

She held out her hands. Cupped.

He poured the teeth into her cupped palms.

She did not drop them.

She shrieked. High, thin, a sound that bounced off every hard surface in the dock and came back changed. She did not drop them. Her fingers closed over them. She looked at her closed hands. She looked at him. And then, slowly, deliberately, with a gravity that was not in any culture Kyle could name but which her body seemed to know on its own, she bowed.

A full bow. From the waist. Held for two seconds. Her hands stayed cupped at her chest the entire time.

The bow of a child who had just been handed an inheritance she had not asked for and was not yet sure what was going to be expected of her in the carrying of it.

Then she was gone, swallowed by the dark beyond the door, her feet making no sound on the steel because she had been raised in a building where you learned, by five, not to make sound on steel.

Kyle stood for three seconds. The second channel, in a register that was not his, said *that one will outlive most of us*, and Kyle did not recognize the diction at all this time — three subjects deep, possibly four. He did not have the bio-battery to chase it. He let it pass.

He cleaned the blade. The tremor started in his right hand at the four-minute mark, moved to his left, became briefly bilateral — the array's invoice arriving, several thousand calories called in twenty-six seconds, the body presenting the bill. His stomach was a closed fist. He needed protein, carbohydrate, something hot in a bowl, something that required no decisions.

He walked back to the bike. The bike started on the first turn. He swapped the plate two blocks short of the Wicker boundary and continued north on a different fiction.

Part II — Standard Rate

Chen's stall was two blocks south of the freight tier and one alley off the main, and the warm orange of its hood lamp was visible through the rain from a block away the way a hearth was visible through the trees in a children's book Kyle had not read but had heard described.

He walked the bike the last block. The bike rolled easier at walking pace than it rode at speed because the front wheel was true and the bearings were clean and the chain was good and the repaired tensioner held. The math came out the way the math came out.

She was at the counter when he arrived. The apron was clean — a service apron, not the kitchen apron she had been wearing in the apartment, which had had bone broth fat on the front. The service apron did not deal with the stockpot, only with the bowls and the counter and the customers. The apron she had worn at home in front of her wired-jaw husband had been a third apron, and Kyle now retroactively confirmed its existence, because Chen Wei-Lin would not have offered service in a kitchen apron and would not have sat with her husband in a service apron either.

The small scar at the base of her left thumb caught the lamp light. The daughter was somewhere he could not see. She had taken some route Kyle had not mapped from the dock back to here, faster than the bike, which meant she had either run through the airshafts or had a private courier route Carrion Logistics LLC had let her use without anyone asking. The daughter was a freight system unto herself. Kyle filed this for later.

She did not greet him. She set a bowl on the counter — pork bone broth, the fourteen-hour kind, simmering at the back of the stall in a Ming-mark thirty-quart stockpot from Foshan that had been in Chen Wei-Lin's family across two husbands, four children, three cities, and three planets and had been continuously simmering for the better part of forty years across all three. The pot, like the freight elevator, was the only thing in the building that worked. The chili oil was already in the bowl, the way she would remember he liked it for the next four years. She ladled with three quick

dips: once to skim, once to stir, once to draw. The third dip was the one she poured. The first two were a ritual she had not been taught and had refined without thinking about it across thirty-one years of stalls.

He sat. The stool was the right height for him. She had not adjusted it. He had not adjusted it. The geometry was simply what it was the first time.

He ate standing up everywhere else. At Mrs. Chen's, he sat. Not because she had offered the stool. Because the stool, having been offered, was offered, and the discipline of accepting what had been offered was the discipline he had begun the moment she brought the bowl.

He ate. The broth was hot. He ate the whole bowl and did not speak. She did not refill it. She did not move. When he set the chopsticks down she was still standing exactly where she had been. She was looking at him the way she had looked at the chips she had pressed into his hand six hours ago — she had more she wanted to give and no language for the giving, and she was now finding the language.

Cantonese first, low. *Mh̄gōi*. Two syllables doing the work of an entire ledger. Then, in the tongue she had chosen to run the stall in because she did not assume every customer spoke hers:

"Free. Always. For you. Forever."

Her hands were flat on the counter beside the bowl. Her scarred thumb was the closest thing to him on the wood. She had just offered him the only thing she owned.

Kyle reached into his coat and set a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate. The kind of standard rate a man paid when he wanted the transaction to be a transaction and not the beginning of an obligation he had spent his life refusing to accumulate.

"I pay. Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time."

She did not pick up the chip. He did not pick up the bowl. The standoff lasted four seconds and was the most important four seconds of their

relationship, and they both knew it without naming it.

She tried again, slower, the way you tried again with a man you had decided not to insult by giving up on the first refusal.

"You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing."

Kyle did not move the chip.

"If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays."

The four seconds became five.

Her hand closed over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth — not refusing the gift, accepting that the gift was the form the man in front of her needed the gift to take.

She bowed. Not the convulsive bow of the apartment six hours ago. A smaller bow. The bow of a vendor accepting a customer's price. The kind of bow she would give him every night, three hundred nights a year, for the next four years and longer.

He stood. He bowed back, smaller still — the bow of a man who had just successfully refused a kindness larger than he could carry.

"Tomorrow. Same bowl. Same price."

"Same price."

The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond.

He turned and walked the bike out of the stall's lamp circle. The rain had not stopped. It was not going to stop tonight. The towers leaned in overhead the way they did this far down. The bruise in the sky was the bruise. A fourth VTOL crossed it going northeast — Arcturus board-floor late-shift letting out, by the timing, secondary commute to the unofficial late-night dining option three blocks south of the corporation district that Kyle had

been to once in 2222 on a job and which had been, even by the standards of unofficial late-night dining options, depressing.

He laughed. Not the laugh the action movies he had never watched had taught the audience to expect. A single tight exhalation, the laugh of a man who had just seen the joke and decided the joke was funny anyway. The joke was that he had walked into a room of six men who would have killed an ordinary person for trying it, and he had walked out, and he was now refusing free noodles from a woman whose entire life he had just rearranged, and he was doing it because honor was a discipline and the discipline did not bend for noodles, and any reasonable observer would have concluded he had lost his mind.

He had not lost his mind. He was just the exception to the rule. The rule said: a man performing samurai discipline in 2226 will be killed for it inside a year. The rule was correct about almost everybody. It was not correct about Kyle because Kyle was very good at the discipline, and the city, for all its talk, had not yet built a counter for *very good at the discipline*. It had built counters for many things. Kyle was none of them.

He was going to die at some point, probably soon, probably for reasons that had nothing to do with whether he was good at it.

In the meantime, the noodles had been the right temperature, the chip had stayed on the counter, the rain was warm at this tier, the bike was running clean, and the world was the world but it was, this evening, the world at a tempo he could ride.

He laughed once more, smaller, almost to himself, and rode home.

Part III — The Watcher

Somebody had been watching the loading-dock work.

The camera was on the second floor of the building across the alley, in a window that had been boarded over for the last eleven years, and a panel of the plywood had been replaced with a panel that looked like the rest but was not. The camera saw through it. The feed ran on a private channel that did not touch the Carrion Logistics LLC grid. Carrion Logistics LLC did not know about the camera. Nobody on the dock had. Kyle had known the way you knew about a draft — by feel, with no source.

The watcher was a woman named Hira Volkova, forty-two, fifteen years in the work, drank tea because coffee made her hands shake and the hands had to stay still on the audio sliders, and kept a bowl of dried apricots on the desk that she did not actually like but that were quiet to eat, because the audio feed needed her not to make sound while it ran. She watched the walk back from the dock to the bike. She noted that the pace did not change, that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya at any point, that the breathing telemetry her organization had access to on ambient infrastructure that did not officially exist stayed at the rest cycle. She noted, in particular, the cut to the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam, which had not produced a flare or an arc or anything else her organization had been told to watch for, because there had been nothing to flare with — the blade had found a gap and the gap had not held — and she wrote this in the report her organization had paid for and which her organization preferred to be correct.

She noted one thing she did not write down.

On a microphone better than anyone on the dock had known was present, she caught Kyle muttering a phrase between the boss's wrist falling and the blade going back in the saya. Three syllables. Not in any language Kyle spoke. Hira ran it against eleven candidate corpora and got an eighty-one-percent match to a sub-variant of Tocharian B that had not been adequately preserved in any extant corpus and that the algorithm had had to triangulate

against three partial inscriptions and a guess. The translation came back, approximately, as *we have him now*.

Hira did not put the Tocharian in the report.

She filed it on the encrypted side of her personal log, on a directory she had not touched in three years, because she had been doing this work for fifteen years and had learned that the things you filed separately were the things that turned out, eventually, to be the answer.

The report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, the south-arm cell captain of the Lotus Syndicate, who would close the file and pass it to her gang lieutenant Mira along with a second file labelled *Bucktown — first interview — fourteen-piece*. The second file would lead to the third, and the third to the fourth. The Tocharian was not in the report Hua read. It would not surface for some time.

Kyle rode home. The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were. He did not yet know that he had begun to be assembled into a shape that was no longer his own, by people who had been watching since before Mrs. Chen had called, on a clock the city kept that he would only ever see parts of. That was the work of years.

Tonight was the work of one night, and tonight the work was done.

Hira put another apricot in her mouth, chewed it without enthusiasm, and watched the bike's running light fade north into the rain.

The city continued.